Prof. Sarabhai's optimism was highly contagious. The very news of his coming to Thumba would electrify people and al laboratories, workshops and design offices would hum with unceasing activity. People would work virtual y round the clock because of their enthusiasm to show Prof. Sarabhai something new, something that had not been done before in our country—be it a new design or a new method of fabrication or even an out-of-the-way administrative procedure. Prof. Sarabhai would often assign multiple tasks to a single person or a group. Though some of those tasks would appear total y unrelated in the beginning, they would, at a later stage, emerge as deeply interconnected. When Prof. Sarabhai was talking to us about the Satel ite Launch Vehicle (SLV), he asked me, almost in the same breath, to take up studies on a rocketassisted take-off system (RATO) for military aircraft. The two things had no apparent connection except in the mind of this great visionary. I knew that al I had to do was to remain alert and focussed on my purpose, and sooner or later, an opportunity to do a chal enging job would enter my laboratory.

Prof. Sarabhai was ever-wil ing to try out novel